

Adar Poonawalla: CEO Serum Institute of India *Changing the Narratives in Vaccine Manufacture as a Global Titan*

As the government races toward its goal for attaining global recognition as a 'Developed India' by 2047, the contributions of enabled leaders are at the very heart of this vision. Standing tall amongst these is Adar Poonawalla, CEO Serum Institute of India (SII), the visionary leader in global healthcare and vaccine innovation is firmly in the seat driving healthcare self-reliance, global pharmaceutical leadership, and economic growth.

Also known as the 'Vaccine Man' who took India's vaccines to a hundred countries, Adar has established the country as a leader, not a follower in the global pharma landscape.

Steered by his high energy and global outlook SII has gained both fame and fortune propelling its stature as the world's largest vaccine manufacturer by number of doses produced and sold globally (more than 1.5 billion doses), to guarantee affordable, mass-produced doses for critical diseases like malaria, dengue, cervical cancer (HPV), and chikungunya. SII also manufactures the Polio vaccine, along with Diphtheria, Tetanus, Pertussis, Hib, BCG, r-Hepatitis B, Measles, Mumps, Rubella, Pneumococcal and Covid-19 vaccines.

Its development work in creating new vaccines and building capacity remain a critical focus point, amply supported by its growing manufacturing facilities, powered by cutting-edge automation and capabilities to handle up to three billion doses over the years to come. Serum Institute of India has the flexibility to produce vaccines in more than one plant, thus facilitating production of large numbers of doses in the shortest time frame. This enables the Institute to improve the response time to cater

to any international emergency or outbreak.

Adar who joined SII in 2001, after graduating from the University of Westminster in London went on to focus on the company's international market and ensuring new products were licensed and pre-qualified by the World Health Organization for supply to United Nations Agencies including UNICEF and PAHO. He continued to lead the expansion of SII, developing affordable vaccines for global outbreaks – including the Covid-19 vaccine, as well as for preventable diseases, particularly in low- and middle-income countries. Many new vaccines such as Rotavirus and Pneumococcal have been produced under his watch.

In 2017, he was appointed as Brand Ambassador for Swachh Bharat, a country-wide campaign to improve waste management. He has led from the front to help fund public infrastructure, health clinics, and waste-management projects, channelising them through the Viloo Poonawalla Charitable Foundation to strengthen grass-root developmental goals.

While vaccines remain the core business, Adar's restless spirit has found new avenues to channelise his energies. Stepping into different verticals offered fresh challenges. In 2019 Adar set up Poonawalla Finance, an NBFC focusing which provided business loans, personal loans, and loans to professionals; in the first year of operations, he grew it to have assets under management of Rs1,000 cr. Having picked up a controlling stake in the Kolkata-headquartered Magma Fincorp (now Poonawalla Finance) he was able to leverage its



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insurance business, Magma HDI, which allowed him to step into India's burgeoning insurance sector. He also invested in the Mumbai-based omnichannel retail pharmacy chain, Wellness Forever.

Adar's foresight and market savvy inclinations continue to direct his future-forward vision as he contemplates opportunities in developing areas such as the green tech business.

Adar also has found new ways of engaging with the public by focusing on the right causes through compelling storytelling propelled by a collaboration with filmmaker Karan Johar's Dharma Productions.

Meanwhile, he continues to focus on building SII as a blue-chip company to compete with the best and brightest in a global scenario in terms of revenues, not just volumes.